# Socialism in Europe and the Russian Revolution

## The big idea

After the French Revolution, Europeans argued about how much society should change. Some wanted almost nothing to change, some wanted gradual reform, and some wanted to overturn society completely. In **Russia in 1917**, a revolution brought the **Bolsheviks** to power and created the world's first **socialist** state, which then influenced the whole twentieth century.

## Age of social change: liberals, radicals, conservatives

| Group | What they wanted |
|---|---|
| **Liberals** | A nation tolerating all religions; individual rights against governments; elected parliament and independent judiciary. But they were **not democrats**: they wanted voting rights only for **men with property**. |
| **Radicals** | Government based on the majority; supported women's suffrage; opposed privileges of big landowners and factory owners (but did not oppose private property itself). |
| **Conservatives** | Opposed radicals and liberals; after the French Revolution accepted that some change was inevitable but wanted it **slow**, respecting the past. |

**Industrial society** brought long working hours, poor wages, unemployment, and housing and sanitation problems in fast-growing towns. This raised the "social question".

**Socialism:** socialists were against **private property**, which they saw as the root of social ills. They wanted property to be controlled by society as a whole.

- **Robert Owen** (England) built a cooperative community called **New Harmony** in Indiana (USA).
- **Louis Blanc** (France) wanted the government to encourage cooperatives.
- **Karl Marx and Friedrich Engels** argued that industrial society was **capitalist**: capitalists owned the capital invested in factories, while workers' labour created the profit. Workers had to overthrow capitalism and build a **communist society** where all property is socially controlled.

By the 1870s socialists formed the **Second International**. In Britain socialists and trade unionists formed the **Labour Party** (1905); in Germany, the **Social Democratic Party (SPD)**.

## The Russian Revolution

**Russia under the Tsar:** In 1914 **Tsar Nicholas II** ruled Russia and its empire. About **85%** of the people were farmers. Industry was small (St Petersburg and Moscow), and workers worked up to 15 hours. Peasants wanted the nobles' land and had their own commune, the **mir**.

The **Russian Social Democratic Workers Party** (founded 1898) split into the **Bolsheviks**, led by **Vladimir Lenin**, who wanted a disciplined party of committed revolutionaries, and the **Mensheviks**, who wanted a party open to all, as in Germany.

**1905 Revolution:** On **Bloody Sunday** (January 1905) workers led by **Father Gapon** marched to the Winter Palace and over 100 were killed by police. Strikes followed and the Tsar allowed an elected parliament, the **Duma**, but he dismissed it repeatedly.

**First World War (1914):** Russia lost heavily; by 1917, about 7 million Russians had died. Retreating soldiers destroyed crops, refugees flooded in, and bread shortages and food riots spread. Industries closed.

**February Revolution (1917):** In Petrograd, workers struck (women led many strikes), and soldiers refused to fire on them. On **2 March 1917** the Tsar **abdicated**. A **Provisional Government** of Duma leaders and the **Petrograd Soviet** (council of workers and soldiers) took charge.

**April Theses:** Lenin returned in April 1917 and put forward three demands: end the war, transfer land to peasants, and nationalise banks. He also wanted the Bolsheviks renamed the **Communist Party**.

**October Revolution (1917):** On **24 October 1917**, the Bolsheviks, through a **Military Revolutionary Committee** led by **Leon Trotsky**, seized government offices; the Provisional Government fell. (Under the old Julian calendar these dates are February and October; by our calendar they fall in March and November.)

**After October:** industries and banks were nationalised (November 1917); land became social property and peasants seized nobles' land; old titles banned; Bolsheviks renamed the **Russian Communist Party (Bolshevik)**; the **Treaty of Brest-Litovsk (March 1918)** ended the war with Germany. A **civil war** followed between the "**reds**" (Bolsheviks) and the "**whites**" (pro-Tsarists) and "**greens**" (Socialist Revolutionaries). In **1922** the **USSR** was created. Russia became a one-party state, and centralised planning began with **Five Year Plans** (from 1927).

FEBRUARY VS OCTOBER

The **February** Revolution removed the Tsar. The **October** Revolution brought the **Bolsheviks** to power by overthrowing the Provisional Government. Do not swap them.

## Stalinism and collectivisation

After Lenin died (1924), **Joseph Stalin** led the party. Grain shortages in towns (1927–28) led him to blame rich peasants, the **kulaks**. From **1929** he forced **collectivisation**: peasants had to work on large state-controlled farms called **kolkhoz**, sharing the profit. Those who resisted were punished, deported or

exiled. Production did not immediately rise; the famine of **1930–33** killed over **4 million** people. Many critics within the party were falsely accused, jailed or executed.

## Global influence

- Communist parties formed in many countries, such as the Communist Party of Great Britain.
- The Bolsheviks encouraged colonial peoples; the **Conference of the Peoples of the East (1920)** and the **Comintern** (an international union of pro-Bolshevik socialist parties) were set up.
- **Indians** were influenced too: **M.N. Roy** was a founder of the Mexican Communist Party; the **Communist Party of India** was formed in the 1920s. **Rabindranath Tagore** wrote "Letters from Russia" (1930–31).
- By the 1950s it was clear that the USSR, although industrialised, denied freedom to its citizens; it collapsed in **1991**. Yet socialist ideals of fair distribution of wealth still inspire people.

**BOARD FAVOURITE**

"Write the reasons for the collapse of the Tsarist autocracy in 1917" and "Explain the changes brought by the Bolsheviks after October 1917" are classic 5-mark questions.

## Quick recap

- Liberals (property-owning men vote), radicals (majority rule), conservatives (slow change).
- Socialists opposed private property; Marx and Engels predicted a communist society.
- Bloody Sunday 1905 → Duma; WWI hardships → February 1917 (Tsar abdicates) → October 1917 (Bolsheviks under Lenin).

- Stalin: collectivisation from 1929, kulaks targeted, famine 1930–33.
- USSR formed 1922 and broke up 1991; ideas of socialism spread worldwide, including to India.

## Practice questions

1. Who led the Bolshevik group in Russia?
   (a) Vladimir Lenin (b) Joseph Stalin (c) Alexander Kerensky (d) Father Gapon
2. The elected consultative parliament created in Russia after the 1905 Revolution was called the
   (a) Soviet (b) Mir (c) Duma (d) Kolkhoz
3. Which group in 19th-century Europe wanted voting rights only for property-owning men?
   (a) Radicals (b) Liberals (c) Socialists (d) Communists
4. Which of these was NOT one of Lenin's April Theses demands?
   (a) The war should be brought to a close (b) Land should be transferred to the peasants (c) Banks should be nationalised (d) The Tsar should be restored with limited powers
5. "Kulaks" were
   (a) poor landless labourers (b) members of the Duma (c) Menshevik leaders (d) well-to-do peasants
6. Robert Owen founded a cooperative community called
   (a) Petrograd Soviet (b) Comintern (c) New Harmony (d) Second International
7. The treaty by which the Bolsheviks pulled Russia out of the First World War was
   (a) Treaty of Versailles (b) Treaty of Brest-Litovsk (c) Treaty of Paris (d) Treaty of Vienna
8. What were the main changes brought about by the Bolsheviks immediately after the October Revolution?
9. What was collectivisation? Why did Stalin introduce it?

Answers: 1. a 2. c 3. b 4. d 5. d 6. c 7. b 8. see notes 9. see notes